

On the Consecration, Enthronement, and Coronation of the Supreme Pontiff

Part II, Chapter IX: On the Prayers of Enthronement (excerpt)

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Concerning their antiquity, the manuscript codex of the Vatican Library Barb. lat. 631 (formerly XIV 4) provides us with precious testimony. This parchment codex, written in the eleventh century in the so-called Beneventan script¹, presents a type of Pontifical from the eleventh century. On folios 132v-133v it displays the text of three prayers under the same rubric *Benedictio pape de episcopo facti* [Blessing of a pope made from a bishop], adding nothing further. Although there exist two manuscripts of the Pontifical of even more ancient origin and destined for Roman use, which contain the order of consecration of the supreme pontiff XL and XXXVI without our prayers², nevertheless we believe those prayers to be very ancient and in their substance to ascend to the time when the election of a bishop to the pontificate was still an exception, namely to the tenth or even ninth century. For it is said in the first prayer: *O God, who do not disdain to be present wherever you are invoked with devout mind, be present, we beseech you, to our invocations, and to this your servant N., whom the common judgment of your people has chosen to reach the apostolic summit, may he have attained the highest point. Through...*³.

Certainly, it is not probable that the prayer was composed after the year 1059, since after the decree of Nicholas II, there can scarcely be proper discussion of the “*common judgment of the people*,” indeed, *judgment* was reserved to the cardinal bishops⁴. On the other hand, we believe that the relationships between the texts of the prayers and the practice of papal elections must be recognized. These elections of bishops, as we have already seen, were considered to have been conducted contrary to the canons. Nevertheless, they were always justified by the fact of a common and universal election by the people. Thus concerning Marinus it is said that he was elected “*by the advocacy and election of the Roman people*”⁵; concerning Formosus it is reported: “*Your leading phalanxes and satraps, your common people and your schools, from the greatest to the least, elected him, acclaimed him, praised him, and adored him...*”⁶. In a similar manner concerning John XIII: “*Then by all the Roman people... he is elected*”⁷. We can recognize the same intention in the cited prayer; the common judgment of the people justifies an election conducted contrary to the canons; moreover, the providence of God

is emphasized, by which the elected one has attained the apostolic summit. The prayer, therefore, can be understood from the conditions of the time and of pontiffs elected from among bishops. The third prayer provides a similar argument; for it is said in it: “...look favorably, we beseech You, upon this Your servant whom, violently lifted from a humble chair, we elevate to the throne // of that same prince of the apostles, so that just as he may be increased by the advances of such great dignity, so may he be enriched by the merits of virtues, so that he may worthily bear the burden of ecclesiastical universality with Your assistance, and may receive a reward in return for his merits from You who are the prize and beatitude of Your own. You who live...”⁸. For we have seen in the text of *Auxilius* that the effect of enthronement consists in an increase of apostolic dignity. The same effect is implored in the third prayer: “so that he may be increased by the advances of such great dignity!” It also agrees with what those present said, namely, that the prayer was given in the conducting to the apostolic see, for the third prayer can properly be called the prayer of enthronement. We find, therefore, various relationships between the conditions of the ninth century, when the first bishops were elected as pontiffs, and these prayers, so that it should not be deemed improbable, at the very least, that they arose in this same time or not long afterward, and that as to their substance they can already be ascribed to the time of Formosus.

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1. {org. 294} E. A. Loew, *The Beneventan Script. A History of the South Italian Minuscule*, Oxford 1914, 292 n. 2, 365.↵
 2. {org. 295} Cassinese Codex 451 and Codex D. 5 of the Vallicellian Library, concerning which cf. ANDRIEU, *Ordines* I 194, 200, 527. — The Pontifical preserved in Sessorian Codex 52 of the Vittorio Emanuele National Library in Rome is indeed for the use of the pontifical chapel, but other orders for the consecration of the Supreme Pontiff are also missing. It is from the 11th century and today bears the number 2096. Concerning it cf. ANDRIEU l. c. I 287-294, 484, 472.↵
 3. {org. 296} Text according to Barb. lat. 631 fol. 132 v-133. (The symbol // indicates the beginning of a new folio).↵
 4. {org. 297} Decree of the year 1059 § 2, EBERS 44.↵
 5. {org. 298} *Invectiva in Romam*, ed. Dümmler, *Gesta Berengarii* 145.↵
 6. {org. 299} *Ibidem* 141.↵
 7. {org. 300} *Continuatio Reginonis* for the year 965, *Rer. Germ. SS.* 176.↵
 8. {org. 301} Barb. lat. 631, fol. 133-133 v.↵